

Q What are the most useful items to buy for my pregnancy wardrobe?

Dressing a rapidly growing belly can seem tricky at first, but you can get great mileage from a small collection of key maternity items, especially if you mix and match with your existing accessories to suit the occasion.

You may want to build up your pregnancy wardrobe gradually, buying a few core pieces—perhaps one or two pairs of maternity pants or jeans, a dress, and a couple of tops—and then add one or two new items to suit your ever-changing shape. If you buy maternity clothes in neutral colors, it will be easy to mix and match them with floaty tunics or wrap-around tops, and existing clothes such as cardigans and jackets that you can continue wearing unbuttoned. Neutral pieces can also be styled with scarves or jewelry to give you a range of outfits.

A good pair of maternity jeans can be very versatile and work as both daytime and evening wear. They come in a variety of styles and waist options: some have a stretchy, expandable “bandeau-style” belly panel; some are designed with elastic side

pieces that allow the waistband to stretch as you get bigger; and others have a low-rise waistband that sits beneath your belly. Look for stretchy cotton denim that is soft and comfortable to wear, even in the latter stages of pregnancy.

In addition to a pair of maternity jeans, you may want to invest in:

» **A pair of plain pants** to wear with a shirt or top and cardigan or jacket for work, or with a dressier top for evenings out.

» **A maternity dress or tunic.** Wrap-around styles are perfect, as you can let them out as you grow, or choose an empire-waist tunic, which is flattering and works well with stretchy leggings.

» **Tops such as T-shirts, tanks,** and long-sleeved tops, depending on the season.

» **Maternity tights** and leggings.

One of the most **hardworking** and **valuable** items in your pregnancy wardrobe is likely to be a pair of **maternity jeans**.

Sizing

Many maternity clothing lines advise you to stick with your pre-pregnancy size when buying maternity wear, but proportions are not necessarily the same across brands. If you can, try on some items first to check how true-to-size a brand's sizing is. Some stores have pillows in different sizes that replicate your growing belly—you can wear these when you try on clothes to see if the size is correct and works for you.

You might be tempted to buy regular clothes in bigger sizes, but beware the larger overall proportions they will have. It is likely they will fit poorly on the shoulders and arms and that hemlines will ride up at the front and won't hang properly over your belly.



Maternity pants If you find a comfortable, well-fitting pair of maternity jeans, you should be able to wear them right up until the birth, and beyond.

Q I have a limited budget. Where can I find stylish but inexpensive maternity wear?

While your pregnancy is wonderful news, it does bring with it a financial cost, as you also need to factor in the nursery and travel equipment your baby will require. Fortunately, it's perfectly possible to be financially prudent and keep costs low when putting together your maternity wardrobe. Most box stores and department stores now stock good maternity clothes, which typically include many affordable basics that won't break the bank. If the timing works out and you plan ahead, you may be able to get some good deals in end-of-season sales that could be in the right season by the end of your pregnancy.

Be open, too, to any offers of maternity clothes from friends, sisters, and cousins who may be happy to pass on their entire maternity wardrobe, even if they are a slightly different size; many maternity items, particularly tops, can fit a range of sizes. You can always consider a clothing trade if that makes you feel easier about accepting the clothes.

Bargain hunting

Buying secondhand maternity clothes is well worth considering, since they are often in extremely good condition because many items are worn just a handful of times. Check out the local secondhand stores in your area that may sell maternity clothes, and also research consignment shop clothing stores, which can be a great place to hunt down some maternity bargains. Tag sales can be another great place to find clothes for a steal, and also take a look at maternity “bundles” on auction websites where new moms auction their maternity wardrobe in one lot.

Are your **shoes** feeling tight? You're not imagining things—some women find that their shoe **size increases** as **relaxin** loosens their foot ligaments. The new shoe size can be permanent.